We were down by the pool earlier in the day and I sat next to Paul. Suddenly, he turned over on his sun bed.

‘Do you know something, David? I love you. You’re a great young player and you’re a great lad. I love playing soccer with you.’

I looked at him. This was me, listening to one of England’s greatest-ever players.

‘I really want to go to this World Cup, David. I want to play in this World Cup with you.’

He said that more than once. He must have heard the rumor that he might be left out. It wasn’t until later that we all found out what had happened, that the manager had told him he wasn’t in the 22 and that Paul had gone mad. Gary Neville was in the room next door to Gazza’s and heard the shouting and the furniture flying. I must admit that by the time that news came through I was more concerned about a couple of my United team-mates.

The fact that Gary and Phil Neville, Paul Scholes, Nicky Butt and I were so close made it even worse when Phil and Butty missed out. A couple of days before, one of the staff had even given Phil a wink, as if to say he was going to be in the squad. That only made his disappointment harder to take. I went up to see them as soon as I found out. Their flight home was in an hour’s time and they were standing in their room, bags packed. I gave Phil a big hug. The five of us had grown up together and now two of them were on their way home. It must have hurt Gary even more, saying goodbye to his brother. Thinking about it now, of course, Butty and Phil had plenty of time ahead of them in international soccer. Paul Gascoigne had just missed out on his last chance of representing his country.

I wasn’t the only one upset about the boys who’d been left out and the way they’d had to find out about it. We had a training session the next morning that was just about as bad as any I can remember. The atmosphere was eerie. We were just expected to get straight on with it. I realized the World Cup was only days away, but I felt there needed to be a time to relax, to take stock of things as a group. With Glenn, the intensity never dropped. Even when we had an evening off, we’d find ourselves all in a room with a bar, downstairs at the hotel, with the doors shut and the curtains drawn, so nobody could get near us. What we really needed was something different occasionally: perhaps just to sit in reception for an hour or two, sign some autographs for the kids and chat with England supporters. Everybody felt really low but nothing was said about the situation. The other lads had gone